
If only Britain was as nice as Americans make it look

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Student and tutor Jamie Davenport (Corey Mylchreest) in Netflix's My Oxford Year Credit: Chris Bake/PA

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There is a very long tradition of American television getting Britain wrong. One of my favourite abominations is the 1972 Columbo episode *Dagger Of The Mind*, in which – I kid you not – the scruffy but infallible LA detective is posted to London to learn from the policing techniques of Scotland Yard. He soon stumbles upon a murder mystery centring around a West End production of *Macbeth*.

The episode was mostly filmed on location in grey and grimy London, but then the action shifts to the country seat of the deceased Sir Roger Haversham, which has the unmistakable air of Beverly Hills – glorious sunshine and abundant orange blossom, one of those instant architectural wonders of Tudor England dropped on Hollywood in the early 20th century. Every character Columbo meets in London is either very posh, or very common. On American TV, Britons fall into only these two categories. You're either Lord Ponsington-Smythe, or 'Iggins from 'ammersmith.

Fifty-three years after *Dagger Of The Mind*, *My Oxford Year* – a new film on Netflix – very much continues this depiction of Britons. It sees hotshot American student Ana de la Vega (Sofia Carson) arriving on our shores to fulfil her big dream of studying English Literature at the University of Oxford. She has barely had time to turn around under the dreaming spires before she falls for fellow student and tutor Jamie Davenport (Corey Mylchreest). There is more than a mere morsel of Meghan Markle to the character of Anna – given to tweeness, simpering, wooed by a posh chap against various grand backdrops.

But despite being filmed in Oxford, the Oxford depicted in *My Oxford Year* is a curious place indeed. My mother's family came from there, so I've seen a lot of the place over the years. It doesn't match the version here, which is oddly clean, and with university buildings conveniently devoid of tourists. At one point, Anna visits a chip shop, which is staffed by a proper "cor guvnor strike a light and Bob's your uncle" Cockney; unlikely enough in London, let alone the Shires.

Meanwhile anyone who has seen recent Oxford Union debates on YouTube will be surprised at the lack of blue hair and swivelling eyes among Anna's fellow students. Lip service is paid in passing to wokeness – a straight white male student (boo, hiss, etc) makes a pass at Anna, who is of Colombian descent, and calls her "Miss diversity quota" – but this is a production that has no interest in the grim or awkward aspects of university life.

My Oxford Year comes hot on the heels of Lena Dunham's insufferably clichéd *Too Much*, which is likewise packed full of American misconceptions about Britons. The first episode's good one-line-and-out joke about confusing the concepts of an English country estate with a council estate is dragged out to terrifying lengths throughout the entire series.

Megan Stalter as Jessica in Lena Dunham's new TV series, *Too much*, which is packed with American misconceptions about Britons Credit: Netflix/Ana Blumenkron

My personal favourite American Britain appears in the indescribable 1978 film *Sextette*. This tells the story of a sex bomb superstar played by Mae West, who at the time was 85 years old. She checks into a swanky "London" hotel with her sixth husband, Sir Michael Barrington (Timothy Dalton) and becomes involved in a diplomatic crisis. To my knowledge, it is the only disco-musical sex comedy that centres around everybody lusting for an octogenarian.

The taxi cab delivering West and Dalton passes through cheering crowds – second unit material filmed in London. Then it arrives at the hotel, at one side of a wide, wide boulevard where all the cars are driving on the right-hand side of the road. The sheer glamour of the occasion causes a city gent to wave his brolly and bowler hat in the air and cry "Hooray for Hollywood!", as they do.



Can we blame the Americans for getting Britain wrong? The strangest thing for a Briton visiting America for the first time is the eerie familiarity of the place; we are so steeped in American movies and TV that the surface, at least, of American life is second nature to us. They don't have anything like that going back the other way; in fact, we have a habit of reflecting their version of Britain back to them through our own media (*Downton Abbey*, Richard Curtis films) which provide Americans with a slightly wonky portrait of Britain.

Only rarely do we try to recreate America here. There was an episode of Howard's Way that was supposedly set partly in New York. This was achieved using incredibly tight shots next to a skyscraper in what I'm fairly sure was Southampton, plus a passing yellow taxi and a wailing siren sound effect. And who can forget the United Nations Plaza in Superman IV, which is very, very obviously Milton Keynes?

In this century, America's increasing cultural dominance has flattened out many of the cultural differences between us, and our national identity is seen by some as provincial, embarrassing or even shameful. So there is something refreshing about My Oxford Year, which, despite its gaffes, actually loves Britain, in the clumsy way that only a foreigner can.

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